

5.2 Browsers

It's fair to assume that for most computer users, browsers are the most important software. Their development was kickstarted when Windows launched a very user-friendly OS—Windows 95. For the first time, a computer system's usability expanded beyond the realm of expert users. The use of the Internet and the subsequent rise of the WWW and online culture meant that more and more people were using computers to access the Internet. Browsers, in more ways than one, provide a window to the Internet.

Firefox 1.0.7

Firefox, developed by the Mozilla foundation, is one of the most complete Web browsers out there. Its claim to fame comes from the fact that it became the first browser in years to challenge the dominance of Internet Explorer as a browser.

One of the best things about Firefox is that it is ever-evolving in terms of technology. It uses the powerful GECKO engine, which ensures the best possible rendering of Web pages. It has superb support for all things dear to Web developers. Rendering is accurate and fast, and it offers advanced stylesheet support.

Another positive is that DOM support is available and accounted for. Firefox is being developed by the Mozilla Foundation, and the open-source nature of the code ensures that the best possible version is released to the common public, and its flaws, if and when discovered, are fixed within days, if not hours. This ensures a browser that is not only great in appearance, but is also secure, stable and efficient.

One of the advantages that Firefox has had is that it could learn from competitors and market leaders. It put this information to good use and developed a browser that doesn't contain many of the obvious vulnerabilities that IE has, such as ActiveX components, which can often install spyware on users' machines.

Although it's heavily derived from the Mozilla Suite, Firefox